

Royal Mile & Old Town - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

The Old Town: Vertical City

The Royal Mile is a single street that was, for centuries, effectively an entire capital city. Hemmed in by defensive walls, the marshy Nor Loch (now Princes Street Gardens), and the crag-and-tail geology, Edinburgh could not sprawl — so it stacked. The tenements, or “lands,” reached ten to fourteen stories by the seventeenth century, among the tallest residential buildings in the world, and produced a social arrangement striking to every visitor: all classes in one stair, with the professional classes on the desirable middle floors, and the poorest in cellars and garrets. Daniel Defoe marveled that in no city in the world did so many people live in so little room. The narrow closes and wynds running off the Mile — over eighty survive — are the capillaries of that city, each named for a trade or resident: Advocate’s Close, Fleshmarket Close, World’s End Close, the last marking where the city wall once ended the known world for those too poor to pay the toll back through the gate. This density made Edinburgh both squalid — the “Gardyloo” sanitation regime gave it the nickname Auld Reekie — and intellectually explosive: in these few acres, in the mid-1700s, Hume, Adam Smith, Hutton and their circle could all meet within a ten-minute walk, and the Scottish Enlightenment happened substantially in the taverns and clubs off this street. When the Georgian New Town opened across the valley, the professional classes decamped almost overnight, freezing the Old Town as the medieval artifact you’re walking through.

Tell Me More: The Enlightenment in a Half Square Mile

The intellectual density of this street in the 1750s to 1790s has no modern parallel, and it happened in taverns. The Select Society debated in rooms off the Mile; the Poker Club, the Oyster Club, the Cape Club met over claret and oysters — Enlightenment Edinburgh’s genius ran on institutionalized dinner parties, and the physical intimacy of the Old Town made it work: Hume, Adam Smith, the geologist Hutton, the chemist Joseph Black (who discovered carbon dioxide and latent heat), the sociologist Adam Ferguson and the architect Robert Adam all lived within minutes of each other and met constantly. Smith drafted the *Wealth of Nations* partly in Kirkcaldy but argued it here; Hume, cheerfully notorious as “the Great Infidel,” was so beloved that when he built a house in the New Town, the street was informally dubbed Saint David Street by a neighbor’s joke, and the name stuck officially. The period’s emblematic figure might be James Boswell, prowling these closes recording everything, or the printer William Smellie, who edited the first *Encyclopaedia Britannica* — conceived and published in Edinburgh in 1768. Why here? The going explanations: a compact capital that had lost its parliament (1707) and court (1603), leaving lawyers, clergy and professors as the elite with energy to spare; Europe’s best universities charging accessible fees; a Presbyterian literacy culture that made Scotland among the most literate societies on Earth; and the tavern sociability the Old Town’s density enforced. Voltaire’s line — that we look to Scotland for all our ideas of civilization — was only half a compliment and entirely earned.

The Man Who Found Deep Time

Look south from almost anywhere on the Mile and you’ll see the long red cliff of Salisbury Crags below the green hump of Arthur’s Seat. That cliff is one of the birthplaces of modern science, and the man

responsible was very much part of the Enlightenment crowd who drank in these closes.

His name was James Hutton, a farmer, physician and gentleman-thinker, and in the seventeen eighties he did something quietly revolutionary. He read the rocks. At a spot now called Hutton's Section, on the Craggs, he saw molten rock that had forced its way in among older layers of sediment. That told him the Earth was not a finished object created once and left alone. It was a slow engine, endlessly wearing mountains down into the sea, then cooking and lifting the debris into new rock, over and over. And the number of cycles he could read into the stone was so vast that the going wisdom, that the Earth was a few thousand years old, made him nearly laugh.

Hutton presented his Theory of the Earth to the Royal Society of Edinburgh in seventeen eighty-five, and published it soon after with a sentence that still gives geologists a shiver. Of the Earth's history he wrote that we find no vestige of a beginning, and no prospect of an end. At another site, Siccar Point down the coast, his friend John Playfair described the feeling of grasping all that time, saying the mind seemed to grow giddy looking so far into the abyss of it.

This was an earthquake in ideas. For centuries, learned men had put the creation at four thousand and four before Christ, worked out from the Bible. Hutton replaced that cosy little calendar with an ocean of time so deep it had no visible shore. Without that ocean, Charles Darwin would have had nowhere to sail. Evolution needs almost unlimited time, and Hutton is the man who first threw the doors open on it.

So Edinburgh's claim to fame isn't only kings and killings. Right here, within sight of this street, in the same generation that gave us Adam Smith and David Hume, a man looking at a cliff worked out that our planet is unthinkably ancient. He is called the father of modern geology, and his laboratory was a hillside you can walk up in an afternoon. Give the Craggs a respectful glance. They rewrote the age of the world.

The Making of Two Cities

To understand why Edinburgh feels like two cities pretending to be one, you have to know how the second one was born, because it happened deliberately, and fast.

By the mid seventeen hundreds the Old Town had become a victim of its own success. The tenements were dangerously overcrowded, filthy, and prone to fire and collapse, and the wealthy were tired of stepping over the results of gardyloo. So in seventeen sixty-seven the city ran a competition for a brand-new district on the empty ground across the valley to the north. The winner was an almost unknown twenty-six-year-old named James Craig, whose elegant grid of broad streets and squares became the New Town, one of the most complete Georgian cityscapes in the world.

But you can't just build a suburb across a valley that contains a lake, and this lake was the foul Nor Loch, the same green sump into which the Old Town had drained its filth for centuries. So they drained it. The eastern end went first, to allow the North Bridge to be flung across the gap in the seventeen sixties, and the rest was cleared over the following decades to become Princes Street Gardens. The vast quantity of earth and rubble dug from the New Town's foundations was carted over and heaped into a great ramp, still called the Mound, which carries a road to this day.

Then came the exodus. The lawyers, doctors, professors and merchants who had lived stacked above and below the poor in the Old Town lands moved, almost as one, into the airy Georgian terraces across the bridge. Princes Street was built up on one side only, so that its houses could keep the spectacular view back to the castle and the old skyline. And that single decision produced the postcard Edinburgh you'll photograph.

The consequence is the thing every visitor senses. On one side of the drained valley stands the medieval Old Town, a dark, vertical, tangled thing that grew by accident over five hundred years. On the other stands the New Town, a cool, rational, Georgian grid designed by one young man in a single sweep. A

city of two faces, glaring at each other across a filled-in lake. Little wonder its writers keep returning to doubles and split selves. The geography practically insists on it. Today the two towns are listed together as a single World Heritage Site, forever the odd couple that makes Edinburgh, Edinburgh.

St Giles, the Covenant, and a Thrown Stool

St Giles' Cathedral, with its crown steeple, has been the stage for Scotland's religious drama for nine centuries, and one incident here arguably lit the fuse of the British civil wars. On the twenty-third of July, 1637, Charles the First imposed a new Anglican-style prayer book on the Scottish Kirk; when the Dean began reading it in St Giles, a market-woman named Jenny Geddes — so tradition holds — hurled her folding stool at his head, crying that he dared say Mass in her ear. The riot that followed grew into the National Covenant of 1638, signed by thousands in Greyfriars Kirkyard nearby, some reputedly in their own blood; the Covenanting rebellion drew Charles into wars he couldn't fund, forcing him to recall the English Parliament — and the road runs from Jenny's stool more or less directly to the scaffold at Whitehall in 1649. Inside, seek out the Thistle Chapel, a jewel of 1911 Gothic revival craftsmanship for Scotland's order of chivalry — among the carved angels is one playing bagpipes. Outside the west door, the cobblestone Heart of Midlothian marks the Old Tolbooth prison, demolished 1817; spitting on it began as contempt for the prison and persists as luck. And John Knox, the Reformation's thundering preacher at St Giles, lies somewhere beneath parking bay twenty-three of the car park behind the cathedral — an arrangement he would either have hated or, as an enemy of veneration, rather approved of.

Tell Me More: The Reformation's Long Shadow

To decode what you're seeing inside St Giles — and in Scotland's ruined abbeys everywhere — a compact Reformation primer. Scotland's Reformation of 1560 was faster and more thorough than England's: driven by Knox from this pulpit, Parliament abolished papal authority and the Mass in a single session, and the Kirk that emerged was Presbyterian — governed by assemblies of elders, no bishops — which put it on a collision course with Stuart kings who understood, correctly, that bishops they appointed were royal control. “No bishop, no king,” said James the Sixth, who knew both jobs. Hence a century of oscillation: James and Charles the First imposing bishops and liturgy, Scotland resisting (Jenny Geddes's stool, the Covenant), Cromwell conquering, the Restoration re-imposing bishops and persecuting Covenanters in the “Killing Time” of the 1680s — field preachers shot, the Covenanters' Prison in Greyfriars Kirkyard holding hundreds in the open air — until 1690 settled Presbyterianism for good. The material consequences surround you: Scottish churches were stripped of images and organs (St Giles got its first post-Reformation organ only in the nineteenth century), the medieval abbeys — Melrose, St Andrews, Holyrood's ruined nave — decayed once their institutions dissolved, and the national temperament acquired its stereotype of austere, argumentative literacy: every parish a school, so every believer could read Scripture, which is a large part of why Enlightenment Scotland could happen at all. The crown spire above you, one of the few pre-Reformation survivals, is thus a rarity: Edinburgh's skyline mostly commemorates what the Reformation built, not what it inherited.

A Cathedral That Isn't, and a Chapel of Thorns

Before you go inside St Giles, a small confession about its name. Everyone calls it a cathedral, but strictly it isn't one, and never really was for long. A cathedral is simply the church that contains a bishop's seat, and St Giles held a bishop only during two brief and unhappy experiments with rule by bishops, from sixteen thirty-three to sixteen thirty-eight, and again from sixteen sixty-one to sixteen eighty-nine. For the rest of its nine centuries it has been a parish kirk, properly the High Kirk of Edinburgh. So the grandest church on the Mile carries a title it wore for barely thirty years.

Look up at the crown steeple, that stone coronet held aloft on flying arches. It dates from the fourteen sixties and is one of only a handful of true crown spires left in the world, a genuine survivor of the pre-Reformation church, since the reformers stripped almost everything else away. Inside, the building

is really several churches folded into one, because for centuries it was subdivided by walls into separate congregations sharing a single roof.

Then find the Thistle Chapel, tucked off the south-east corner, and slow right down. This is the private chapel of the Order of the Thistle, Scotland's senior order of chivalry, revived by King James the Seventh in sixteen eighty-seven. Its motto is a splendid warning, *nemo me impune lacessit*, no one provokes me and gets away with it, the same growl you'll find around a thistle on Scottish coins. The chapel itself was designed by Robert Lorimer and opened in nineteen eleven, and it is a riot of carved oak and stone, with stalls for sixteen knights. Hunt among the angels overhead for the famous one, a small stone angel calmly playing the bagpipes.

And here's the detail I love best. Somewhere within a few paces of each other, this church holds grand monuments to the Marquess of Montrose and the Marquess of Argyll, the two greatest enemies of the Covenanting wars. Montrose fought for the king and was hanged and butchered outside this very door in sixteen fifty. Argyll led the radical Covenanters and was beheaded, likewise nearby, just eleven years later. In life they would gladly have destroyed each other. In death, thanks to a pair of proud Victorian memorials, they lie in effigy almost within touching distance, reconciled at last by nothing more than a shortage of space.

Knox, Mary, and the Woman with the Stool

Two figures haunt St Giles above all others, one a thundering man who certainly existed, and one a defiant woman who may not have. Let's take them in turn.

John Knox was the minister here, and the engine of Scotland's Reformation in fifteen sixty. He had trained under the continental reformers, survived a spell as a French galley slave, and came home to preach with a ferocity that terrified kings. He is notorious for a pamphlet with an unforgettable title, the *First Blast of the Trumpet Against the Monstrous Regiment of Women*, an attack on the idea of Catholic queens ruling, which he published just before, awkwardly, a Protestant queen took the English throne. His timing was rarely diplomatic.

His great antagonist was Mary, Queen of Scots, the young Catholic monarch newly returned from France. Knox was summoned before her several times, and the encounters became legendary. She reasoned, she pleaded, and on at least one occasion she wept, and Knox, by his own proud account, did not bend an inch. He simply out-argued and out-last-ed her, and history, for better or worse, moved his way. When he died in fifteen seventy-two he was buried in the kirkyard that once surrounded St Giles. That graveyard is long gone, paved into Parliament Square, so today Scotland's fiercest reformer lies beneath a car park. A marker sits in parking space number twenty-three, and the old memorial stone now rests inside the kirk. He, an enemy of relics and veneration, might have found the parking space perfect.

Now the woman. The tale goes that in sixteen thirty-seven, when the dean began reading the hated new prayer book, a market trader called Jenny Geddes hurled her folding stool at his head and cried that he'd not say Mass in her ear, sparking the riot that grew into the Covenant. It's a wonderful story, and here honesty is owed. Records show a Geddes of roughly that description may indeed have lived, but many historians treat the stool-throwing as legend, probably stitched together decades later from two separate accounts of the riot. The riot itself was entirely real, and so were its consequences. Whether one particular stool truly flew, we simply cannot prove. A small bronze sculpture of a three-legged stool, given by a group of Scotswomen in nineteen ninety-two, marks the supposed spot. Treat it as Edinburgh treats it, half history, half heroine, and wholly part of the story.

The City Beneath: Closes, Vaults and Plague Stories

Edinburgh's Old Town has a genuine underground layer, and it's more interesting than the ghost tours suggest. Two different things get conflated. First, Mary King's Close: in the 1750s, the city built the Royal Exchange (now the City Chambers) directly on top of a warren of existing closes, decapitating the tenements and using their lower floors as foundations — preserving seventeenth-century streets, rooms and all, beneath the building. The attached legend, that plague victims were walled up alive there in 1645, is not supported by records — quarantined residents were supplied with food, and plague cleaning was a paid municipal service performed by workers in early hazmat gear of waxed cloth — but the real story of the 1645 epidemic, which killed perhaps half the city, needs no embellishment. Second, the South Bridge vaults: when the bridge was built in the 1780s, its nineteen arches were enclosed and the chambers within used as workshops and storage, then abandoned to damp and, eventually, to the very poorest of the city — and, plausibly, to less official trades; body-snatchers Burke and Hare operated in exactly this Edinburgh, murdering sixteen people in 1828 to sell to the anatomy schools. The vaults were rediscovered essentially full of rubble in the 1980s. Tonight's takeaway as you walk: the Old Town isn't built on rock alone — it's built on earlier Edinburgh, floor upon floor.

Tell Me More: Deacon Brodie and the City of Doubles

Edinburgh's underground fixation is really a fixation with doubleness, and its patron sinner is Deacon William Brodie: respectable cabinetmaker, city councillor, head of his trade guild by day — housebreaker by night, using wax impressions of his clients' keys, funding gambling debts and two secret families. Caught after a botched excise-office raid in 1788, he was hanged before a huge crowd on a gallows whose design he was reputed (apocryphally, but irresistibly) to have improved himself; legend adds a steel collar and a bribed hangman in a failed survival scheme. Robert Louis Stevenson, whose family owned Brodie-made furniture, grew up on the story — and Brodie is a direct ancestor of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde, which Stevenson set in London but built entirely out of Edinburgh's split anatomy: the respectable New Town facade and the Old Town shadow, one city wearing two faces. The theme recurs everywhere here: Burke and Hare selling murder to the Enlightenment's finest anatomist, Robert Knox, who was never prosecuted — the mob helpfully rhymed “Burke's the butcher, Hare's the thief, Knox the boy who buys the beef”; Conan Doyle deriving Holmes from Dr Joseph Bell's diagnostic performances at the Royal Infirmary, deduction as parlor trick made science; and the city itself, medieval spine and Georgian grid glaring at each other across the drained loch. Tonight's literary footnote: a certain author wrote much of a certain boy wizard in cafés overlooking Greyfriars Kirkyard, where the headstones include a Thomas Riddell. The kids' tour guides will make of that what tour guides do.

Burke, Hare, and the Anatomy Act

Edinburgh's brilliance in medicine had a grim shadow, and it lived in exactly the underground, overcrowded city we've been walking through. The anatomy schools here were the best in the world, and to teach dissection they needed a steady supply of fresh human bodies. The law, which allowed only the corpses of executed criminals, supplied nowhere near enough. So a black market grew, worked by the resurrection men, who dug up the newly buried and sold them, no questions asked.

William Burke and William Hare improved on that grisly trade with an appalling shortcut. Why dig up the dead and risk the spade, when you could simply create the supply yourself? Over roughly ten months in eighteen twenty-eight, the two Irish labourers and their partners lured at least sixteen people, lodgers, strangers, the poor and the friendless, and murdered them. Their method was quiet and deliberate. One would pin the victim and cover the nose and mouth while the other bore down on the chest, leaving few

marks for an anatomist to notice. It was so distinctive that a new word entered the English language, to burke, meaning to smother, or to quietly suppress. They carried the still-warm bodies straight to the dissecting rooms of the celebrated anatomist Doctor Robert Knox, who paid well and asked nothing.

They were undone by recognition. Among their victims were people the city knew, a well-loved street character called Daft Jamie, and a young woman named Mary Paterson, and students began to recognise the fresh cadavers on the slab. When the law finally closed in, Hare was offered a squalid bargain. He turned King's evidence, testified against his partner, and walked free forever. Burke did not. He was hanged in January eighteen twenty-nine before a crowd said to number in the tens of thousands, and then, with a certain dark justice, his own corpse was publicly dissected in the very theatre his murders had supplied. His skeleton still stands in the university's anatomical museum, and a pocketbook bound in his tanned skin survives in a city collection to this day.

The scandal did more than fill the papers. It shamed Parliament into passing the Anatomy Act of eighteen thirty-two, which at last let medical schools obtain bodies legally, through donation and unclaimed remains. The trade in stolen and murdered corpses withered overnight. So the very horror of Burke and Hare is what finally made the dissecting room decent, a typically Edinburgh ending, progress dragged out of the gutter.

Greyfriars: A Poltergeist and a Doubtful Dog

A short walk off the Mile lies Greyfriars Kirkyard, and for a quiet graveyard it packs in an improbable amount of Edinburgh, from national politics to national sentimentality, with a supposed haunting in between.

You already know this is hallowed Covenanting ground. That same rebellion has a darker corner here. After a Covenanter defeat in sixteen seventy-nine, well over a thousand prisoners were held for months in a bare enclosure at the edge of this kirkyard, the so-called Covenanters' Prison, in conditions that killed many. And a few steps away stands the domed tomb of Sir George Mackenzie, the King's Advocate who prosecuted them so savagely that he is still remembered as Bloody Mackenzie. Which sets up the graveyard's modern twist. Since about nineteen ninety-nine, hundreds of visitors near his mausoleum have reported sudden cold, scratches, bruises and faintings, a phenomenon the tour trade calls the Mackenzie Poltergeist, and cheerfully bills as one of the best-documented hauntings in Britain. Bear in mind that well-documented and real are not the same thing, but it is a wonderfully atmospheric place to test your scepticism after dark.

Look, too, for the mortsafes, those heavy iron cages and slabs clamped over graves. They aren't decoration. In the age of Burke and Hare, families bolted their dead down or locked them in cages to stop the body-snatchers, and Greyfriars, being handy for the anatomy schools, needed them badly.

And just outside the gate sits the statue everyone stops to rub, the little terrier Greyfriars Bobby, said to have guarded his master's grave for fourteen years. It's the tender heart of tourist Edinburgh, and it deserves a note of this city's native doubt. The historian Jan Bondeson, after combing the records, argues that the tale was burnished, and perhaps half-invented, by a local restaurateur and the graveyard keeper, both of whom did very nicely from the crowds a famous faithful dog drew in. He even suspects there were two dogs across the years, the first quietly replaced by a photogenic successor, which would neatly explain that suspiciously long fourteen years. What's solid is that a churchyard dog was real and dearly loved, that the statue was unveiled in eighteen seventy-three, paid for by the banking heiress Baroness Burdett-Coutts, and, my favourite footnote, that it was sculpted by a man named William Brodie. No relation to the burglar. In this city of doubles, even the coincidences come in matching pairs.